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Community Engagement and Public Safety: Evidence from Crime Enforcement Targeting Immigrants†

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We study the role of victim reporting in the production of public safety. We examine the Secure Communities program, a crime-reduction policy that involved police in detecting unauthorized immigrants and increased deportation fears in immigrant communities. We find that the policy reduced the likelihood that Hispanic victims report crimes to police and increased offending against Hispanics. The number of reported crimes is unchanged, masking these opposing effects. We show that reduced reporting drives the offending increase and provide the first elasticity of offending to victim reporting in the literature, calculating that a 10 percent decline in reporting increases offending by 7.9 percent. (*JEL* J15, K37, K42)

Criminal activity imposes high social and economic costs, making the advancement of public safety a principal objective of government. In accordance with the canonical model of the economics of crime, which posits that offenders respond to the expected cost of offending (Becker 1968), scholars and policymakers regard criminal enforcement as a key tool for reducing crime. Enforcement is primarily carried out by government employees, but it also hinges on civilian participation: the police only learn about crimes when victims and witnesses report incidents.

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Without victims reporting crimes to the police, enforcement policy could become less effective, and public safety may worsen.

While victim reporting is a central input into law enforcement, the willingness to report crimes may itself be influenced by the broader enforcement environment. Residents may be less likely to engage with the police when they perceive enforcement to be disproportionate or unfair (Owens and Ba 2021), and mistrust can be exacerbated by events like high-profile instances of police violence (Ang, Bencsik, Bruhn, and Derenoncourt 2025; Mikdash and Zaiour 2024). Immigration enforcement, in particular, is often viewed as a policy area that carries significant risks for civilian cooperation. Though the goal of much of immigration enforcement policy is the advancement of public safety, a competing concern is that it induces fear within immigrant communities (Alsan and Yang 2024). Residents may, as a result, become less willing to report crimes. Despite the theoretical significance of victim reporting, there is a dearth of empirical evidence examining the causal impact of victim behavior on public safety,[1] limiting our understanding of the tradeoff between enforcement and community engagement.

This paper studies the role of victim reporting in the production of public safety, and our central contribution is to provide the first estimate of the elasticity of offending with respect to victim reporting. We do so using a range of survey and administrative data combined with quasi-experimental variation in enforcement induced by US immigration policy. Specifically, we study the Secure Communities (SC) program, a federal policy which significantly increased deportations of immigrants arrested for criminal offenses and whose stated goal was to reduce crime. During the program's implementation, law enforcement officials across the country expressed skepticism about the program's crime-reduction potential because of the possibility that it would deter victims from engaging with the police.[2] Guided by these competing predictions about the program's impact on public safety, our analysis proceeds by estimating three empirical objects: how victim reporting responded to changes in enforcement, how criminal offending responded to changes in enforcement, and the causal link between victim reporting and offending.

Studying the relationship between victim reporting and criminal offending requires overcoming two key empirical challenges. First, most administrative data only include crimes that have been reported to law enforcement, meaning that criminal offending and victim reporting are combined into a single measure of crime. This measurement issue implies that if a policy changes victim reporting, then examining its impact on *reported* crime will yield biased estimates of the true effect on offending. The first half of our paper tackles this central challenge. Second, policies or events that plausibly shift victim reporting are likely to have separate impacts on offending. This fact complicates the task of isolating the causal effect of victim reporting on offending behavior, and it is the focus of the second half of our paper.

We begin by estimating the impact of SC on victim reporting and offending. To overcome the aforementioned measurement challenge, we utilize the National Crime Victimization Survey (NCVS), a nationally representative survey that asks

[1] As an illustrative example, two recent reviews of the economics of crime literature do not mention victim behavior (Nagin 2013; Chalfin and McCrary 2017).

[2] See William J. Bratton, "LAPD, not ICE," *Los Angeles Times*, October 27, 2009.

individuals whether they have been the victim of a crime and, if so, whether they reported that crime to police.[3] The NCVS provides information on respondent ethnicity, allowing us to separately estimate effects for Hispanics and non-Hispanics. This feature is a key advantage relative to most administrative crime data, which typically consist of counts of total reported crimes with no demographic information, and it is crucial in a setting where over 90 percent of deported individuals are Hispanic. We focus on effects for all Hispanic individuals—including citizens and noncitizens—consistent with prior findings that Hispanic citizens also respond to enforcement due to fear that a family member or neighbor may be deported (Watson 2014; Alsan and Yang 2024).

To estimate causal effects, we leverage the differential timing of the implementation of SC, which was staggered across counties due to resource constraints. This program increased information sharing between county jails and federal immigration authorities to facilitate the identification and deportation of immigrants arrested for criminal offenses. We implement a difference-in-differences design and estimate effects separately for Hispanic and non-Hispanic respondents, comparing individuals of the same ethnicity before and after SC adoption across counties with different program status. We confirm that the program led to sharp increases in immigration enforcement: detentions by Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) rose by 54 percent following the program's introduction.

Our first main finding is that SC reduced the likelihood that Hispanic victims reported crime to the police. Hispanics reduced their reporting rate by 9 percentage points, a significant and sizable 30 percent decline relative to the pre-period reporting rate of 33 percent. The decline occurred relatively quickly and appears more pronounced among property offenses. In contrast, we find no changes in the reporting behavior of non-Hispanics. Because police rely on victim reporting to apprehend offenders, this decline in reporting implies a substantially lower likelihood that offenders were caught after committing a crime.

At the same time, the policy *increased* crime against Hispanics. Hispanic victimization (i.e., offending against Hispanics) increased by 0.15 percentage points, a 16 percent increase relative to the pre-period monthly victimization rate. These estimates imply that SC resulted in 1.3 million additional crimes against Hispanics in the two years following program activation. The increase in victimization mirrors the decline in reporting and appears to be largely concentrated among property crimes, which comprise the majority of victimizations. We also estimate similarly sized but less precise increases in violent crime.

As with reporting, there is no change in the overall victimization of non-Hispanic individuals. There is, however, an increase in the victimization of non-Hispanics who live in areas with high shares of Hispanic residents. Across the full population (pooling all respondents), we rule out declines in victimization of more than 3.9 percent, indicating quite precisely that the policy did not achieve its goal of improving public safety. The findings of increased victimization and lower victim reporting are robust to alternative specifications and sample restrictions, as well as accounting for survey attrition and compositional changes among survey respondents and crime victims.

[3] Because our primary measure of criminal behavior comes from a victim survey, we use the terms "victimization," "crime," and "offending" interchangeably throughout the paper.

Our finding of increased victimization stands in stark contrast to prior studies analyzing SC, which concluded that the program had no impact on public safety (Miles and Cox 2014; Treyger, Chalfin, and Loeffler 2014; Hines and Peri 2019). To reconcile these opposing conclusions, we combine our primary outcomes to construct a measure of *reported* crime, analogous to standard measures of crime in the literature. We find that reported crime remains unchanged after the launch of the program, as it masks the opposing changes in victimization and reporting rates. Hence, our analysis not only overturns the prevailing consensus on SC's public safety effects, but it also explains why prior studies systematically failed to detect its true impact. Our findings highlight the need to disentangle victimization from reporting behavior to accurately assess changes in public safety.

In the second half of this paper, we argue that the decline in victim reporting is the primary driver of increased victimization. As we highlight above, an empirical challenge to isolating the effect of victim reporting on offending is that the SC program may have impacted offending through channels other than reporting. To address this challenge, we conduct four complementary exercises that draw on survey data, administrative crime records, and a novel collection of administrative micro-data from over 45 medium and large police departments. These micro-data were hand-collected through records requests to individual police departments, and each record is geocoded to a census tract in order to link the outcomes to neighborhood resident demographics.

We first estimate victimization and reporting effects separately by cohort of program implementation using the NCVS sample. We show that cohorts with larger declines in reporting also experience larger increases in victimization, establishing a clear link between these two outcomes.

Second, we consider changes in police behavior in response to SC as an alternative driver of changes in offending. Although the program operated through the jail system—almost always managed by county sheriffs rather than municipal police departments—we examine the possibility that SC impacted police resources or behaviors. Using both the NCVS and the FBI's Uniform Crime Reports, we show that clearance rates, or the likelihood that a crime which is known to police is solved, remain unchanged after the program's implementation. We supplement this analysis with 911 call records from 16 cities in our novel data collection; using this data, we show that police response times did not change under SC. These results suggest that neither changes in police effectiveness nor police "pulling back" are responsible for the increase in crime.

Third, we examine how the policy affected the ethnic composition of *offenders*. We measure offender demographics using administrative arrest records from 37 cities in our data collection that include consistent data on Hispanic arrestee ethnicity. If a deterioration in Hispanics' economic outcomes were the primary driver of the increase in crime, we would expect the arrestee population to become *more* Hispanic. Our findings indicate that the policy actually *reduced* the Hispanic share of arrestees, providing evidence against economic distress as a driver of increased victimization.

Finally, we conduct a mediation analysis that explicitly accounts for the possible impacts of deportations and other social and economic changes as alternative drivers of the increase in offending. Specifically, we use data on immigration enforcement to estimate SC's impact on deportations and census data to estimate the program's impact on unemployment, wages, and the share of female-headed households. Leveraging elasticities of crime with respect to these factors from the literature, we demonstrate that the increase in victimization cannot be jointly explained by these factors. In fact, the "residualized" change in victimization after accounting for all measured mediators is *larger* than our baseline estimate, ruling out that changes in deportations and socioeconomic factors drove the observed increase in crime. As further evidence of the central importance of victim reporting, we estimate the predicted change in victimization from the observed decline in reporting, using the implied elasticity of offending to reporting from our analysis comparing treatment effects across cohorts. We find that the predicted increase in victimization is strikingly similar to the "residualized" effect from our mediation analysis. Combining our findings from this exercise, our preferred estimate of the elasticity of offending to reporting is -0.79, meaning that a 10 percent decline in victim reporting increases offending by 7.9 percent. This sizable magnitude reinforces that community engagement is central to public safety.

Our primary contribution is to show that victim reporting is fundamental for the production of public safety and to provide the first estimate of the elasticity of offending with respect to victim reporting. Criminal justice scholars have long studied the relationship between trust in law enforcement and willingness to call the police,[4] and recent empirical work has documented changes in victim reporting following events that alter perceptions of law enforcement legitimacy (Ang, Bencsik, Bruhn, and Derenoncourt 2023; Jácome 2022; Mikdash and Zaiour 2024). While prior work has posited that reduced victim reporting could directly harm public safety, existing evidence on this relationship has been limited to qualitative ethnographies and cross-sectional correlations[5] or has focused on specific settings such as domestic violence (Miller and Segal 2019; Golestani 2021) and workplace mistreatment (Grittner and Johnson 2022), in which the offender and victim have an established relationship. Prior work by Comino, Mastrobuoni, and Nicolò (2020) finds that immigration amnesty policies increase victim reporting and hypothesizes that this change may affect public safety, offering suggestive evidence that immigrant victimization declines as a result. Our paper builds on this literature by providing causal evidence *linking* a decline in victim reporting with an increase in offending. This finding is an important contribution to the economics of crime literature, which has predominantly focused on how offenders respond to changes in enforcement with little attention paid to victim behavior. Indeed, our setting is noteworthy in that we study a policy that was meant to reduce criminal offending but instead increased it, precisely because of an unintended impact on victim reporting.

More broadly, this paper speaks to key measurement challenges in the evaluation of criminal justice policy and shows that these issues can generate misleading conclusions. First, a small number of prior studies have emphasized the importance of accounting for civilian reporting when measuring public safety and policing outcomes (Carr and Doleac 2016, 2018; Ba 2018; Miller, Segal, and Spencer

[4] See Tyler and Huo (2002) and Xie and Baumer (2019) for reviews on the relationship between trust in law enforcement and calling the police within sociology and criminology.

[5] See Wright and Decker (1996) and Kirk and Papachristos (2011), respectively.

2022). However, due to data limitations, research studying the effect of enforcement policies has typically relied on administrative data on *reported* crime, primarily the FBI's Uniform Crime Reporting data.[6] We show that victim reporting can respond to an enforcement policy as much as offender behavior, so that changes in reported crime can differ significantly from changes in underlying crime. Second, our findings build on Harvey and Mattia (2024), illustrating that crime data without victim demographics can obscure group-specific effects in contexts where racial or ethnic minorities are disproportionately affected by law enforcement policies. Both of these measurement issues are crucial in our setting: Our estimates would not have detected victimization impacts on Hispanics if we had relied on reported crime or ignored victim ethnicity.

The findings of this study also have implications for the broader design of criminal justice policy. Scholars, law enforcement officials, and activists have warned that various policing practices—such as zero-tolerance policing, "stop-and-frisk" policies, mandatory arrest laws for domestic violence, no-knock warrants, and physical restraint techniques like chokeholds—may reduce victim reporting, compromise police legitimacy, and damage police-community relations (e.g., Fagan and Davies 2000; Fratello, Rengifo, Trone, and Velazquez 2013; Iyengar 2009; Reisig and Kane 2014; US Department of Justice 2021). Building public trust has thus emerged as a key area for reform (Ramsey and Robinson 2015). Our findings expand this debate by showing how certain policies may not only damage victim reporting, but also, as a result, may worsen public safety. Stated differently, we provide direct evidence of a tradeoff between enforcement and community engagement in the provision of public safety.

I. Institutional Background

In 2008, the United States launched the Secure Communities program, an information-sharing initiative intended to promote public safety.[7] This policy expanded the federal government's ability to identify and detain immigrants who were arrested for a criminal offense.

Upon the program's activation, the fingerprints of individuals booked into local jails were not only forwarded to the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) (as they had been historically),[8] but they were also now sent to the Department of Homeland Security (DHS). This agency cross-references the fingerprint records with information on prior immigration infractions, border crossings, or expired visas to determine whether there is reason to deport the individual.[9] If so, the Immigration and

[6] For papers studying the effect of immigration enforcement on reported crime, see Miles and Cox (2014); Treyger, Chalfin, and Loeffler (2014); Pinotti (2015); Hines and Peri (2019); Chalfin and Deza (2020); Amuedo-Dorantes and Deza (2022); and Amuedo-Dorantes and Arenas-Arroyo (2022).

[7] See "ICE Unveils Sweeping New Plan to Target Criminal Aliens in Jails Nationwide," ICE News Release, Department of Homeland Security, March 28, 2008. This initiative aligns with the mission of the Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) agency: to "Protect America through criminal investigations and enforcing immigration laws to preserve national security and public safety" (https://www.ice.gov/mission).

[8] The fingerprints of arrested individuals in a local jail are submitted to the FBI so this agency can conduct a standard criminal background check.

[9] DHS records enable identification of an individual's citizenship and legal immigration status. While the program primarily targeted unauthorized immigrants, any noncitizen immigrant arrested for a crime was eligible for detention through this program.

Customs Enforcement (ICE) agency within DHS issues a "detainer" request (i.e., an immigration hold) asking local officials to keep the individual in their custody until they can be transferred to federal custody for the initiation of deportation proceedings. Because fingerprints of jailed individuals were now automatically forwarded to DHS, local officials could not prevent federal officials from learning about the immigration status of arrested individuals (or opt out of the program). The program's novel ability to screen every arrested person in the country quickly made this program the largest expansion of local involvement in immigration enforcement (Cox and Miles 2013).[10,11]

The implementation of the SC program was staggered on a county-by-county basis due to factors like technological constraints and resource bottlenecks (Miles and Cox 2014). Panel A of Figure 1 and Figure A.1 depict the rollout.[12] Early activation was not correlated with local crime rates; instead, it was correlated with the share of a county's population that is Hispanic, the presence of a 287(g) agreement, and proximity to the border (Miles and Cox 2014). Prior work studying the effects of SC shows that, in terms of economic characteristics and crime, the timing of the rollout can be considered as good as random (East et al. 2023; Medina-Cortina 2022). We confirm these findings in Table A.1: levels and changes in crime rates and in economic characteristics (i.e., a county's unemployment and poverty rates) are not associated with SC activation timing after accounting for county demographic characteristics.

Following the launch of the program, the number of immigrant detentions and deportations rose rapidly nationwide. Figure A.2 shows that the number of "honored" ICE detainers—those that result in a transfer to ICE custody—doubled between 2008 and 2012. The second panel of this figure plots the number of SC program removals (i.e., deportations) that occurred in each month. In any given month, over 90 percent of detainers and removals were of Hispanic individuals. Finally, the scale of local involvement in immigration enforcement is evident in Figure A.3: over half of arrests resulted from local referrals, significantly exceeding the number of arrests that originated via referrals from state and federal prisons or those made directly by ICE in communities (including workplaces).

As SC was established nationally, some scholars and policymakers warned that increasing local involvement in immigration enforcement would compromise engagement with police among immigrant communities, with adverse consequences for public safety (e.g., Kirk, Papachristos, Fagan, and Tyler 2012). In particular, police chiefs voiced concerns about decreased victim engagement due to fear of increased risk of deportation.[13] These concerns are consistent with qualitative interview-based

[10] Prior programs involving local participation in immigration enforcement included the Section 287(g) program and Criminal Alien Program (CAP). By the start of SC, 287(g) agreements were only in place in around 75 jurisdictions, and CAP was only present in a small fraction of local jails (Cox and Miles 2013; Watson and Thompson 2022).

[11] Localities could not prevent federal officials from learning about an arrestee's immigration status; however, they could refuse to hold an individual in jail prior to the arrival of ICE officials (such localities are often termed "sanctuary cities"). Sanctuary cities were very uncommon during the first few years after SC implementation; 95 percent of these policies occurred in 2013–2015 (Hausman 2020), after this paper's sample window.

[12] All figures and tables with an "A." prefix are to be found in our Supplemental Appendix.

[13] In a 2009 opinion piece, LAPD chief William Bratton argued, "Every day our effectiveness is diminished because immigrants living and working in our communities are afraid to have any contact with the police. A person reporting a crime should never fear being deported, but such fears are real and palpable for many of our immigrant neighbors." "LAPD, not ICE," *Los Angeles Times*, October 27, 2009.

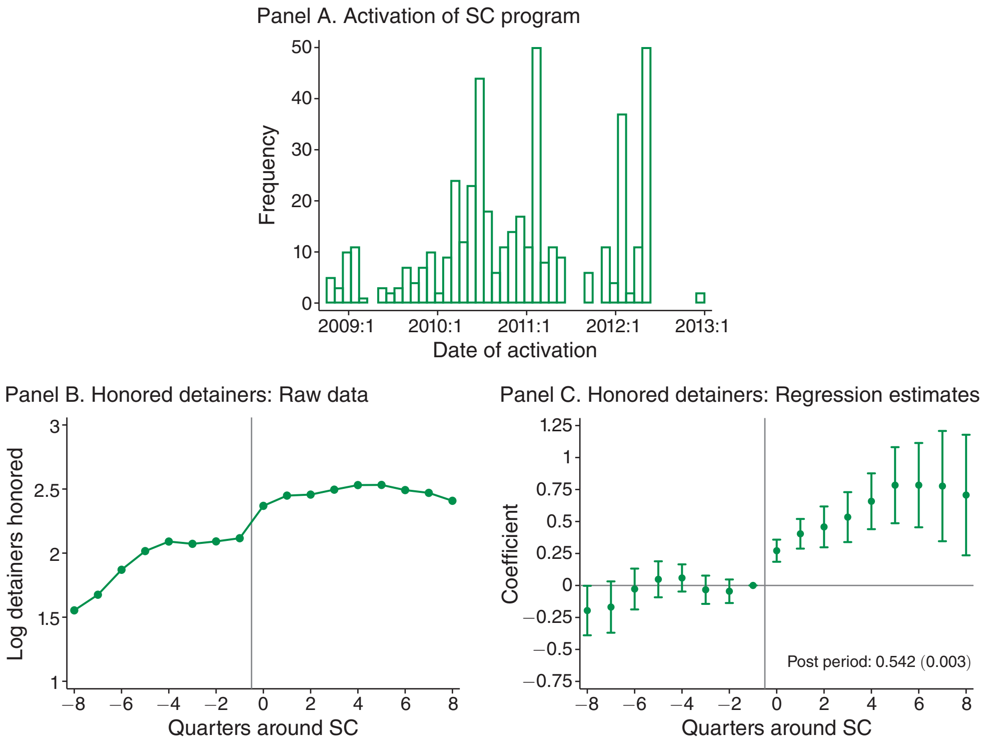

Figure 1. Impact of Secure Communities Program on Immigration Enforcement

Notes: Panel A displays the number of counties that activated the Secure Communities (SC) program by month among counties that meet the sampling restrictions outlined in Section III (i.e., excludes border counties, IL, MA, or NY, and counties with fewer than 100,000 residents in 2000). Panel B plots the raw means of the logged number of honored ICE detainers around the implementation of SC. An honored detainer request refers to an ICE detainer request record that indicates that an individual was booked into detention. Honored detainers are available in both the pre- and post-period and are used in this study as a proxy for ICE removals (deportations). Panel C plots the dynamic difference-in-differences estimates using equation (3) and reports the β_{Post} estimate and corresponding standard error from equation (2). In panels B and C, estimates are weighted by the county's population in that year (US Census Bureau 2022).

research, which finds that offenders target Hispanic victims partly because these victims are less likely to report crimes to police (Caraballo and Topalli 2023).

Why would victims fear interactions with police? While the SC program targeted individuals arrested for criminal offenses, there was a strong community perception that local police were now serving as immigration agents who could ask civilians about their own or others' immigration status and detain any unauthorized individuals (Kohli, Markowitz, and Chavez 2011). The potential risk of deportation for non-offenders or non-serious offenders was acutely salient in the Hispanic community: in a 2012 survey, 44 percent of Latinos (70 percent of unauthorized immigrants and 28 percent of US-born Latinos) reported that they were less likely to contact police if they were a victim of a crime because they feared police would inquire about their immigration status or that of the people they know (Lake et al. 2013). The patterns of actual ICE enforcement did not alleviate these concerns; around 20 percent of individuals transferred from local jails to ICE custody were not charged or convicted of a crime (see Figure A.5).[14] Moreover, even when local police have attempted to guarantee protection for immigrants who cooperate with criminal investigations, local police have often been limited in these efforts given the competing jurisdictional authority of federal immigration agents.[15,16]

Consistent with police chiefs' warnings, a majority of surveyed Latinos reported feeling *less safe* because local police were involved in immigration enforcement and that criminals had moved into their neighborhoods because they knew victims were more reluctant to report crimes (Lake et al. 2013).

II. Conceptual Framework

We outline here a simple conceptual framework to illustrate the predicted impact of SC on crime reporting and criminal victimizations. We build on Becker (1968) and extend it to incorporate the decision of victims to report crimes to the police. We operationalize the SC program as a change in the probability of deportation, which can impact both offenders' and victims' decisions. For expositional simplicity, we assume that all offenders and victims are Hispanic noncitizens, but the main predictions are unchanged if we allow a share of offenders and victims to be citizens. In Supplemental Appendix C, we expand on this framework and discuss various such extensions.

Potential offenders have a single choice of whether to commit an offense, which they make by weighing the associated costs and benefits. There is a uniform benefit of committing a crime M and an offender-specific cost c (e.g., the opportunity cost of committing a crime), which is drawn from a cumulative distribution function $G(c)$ across offenders. Offenders face a probability of getting caught, which is a function of the reporting behavior of victims r (because police can only investigate crimes that are known to them) and the probability police arrest the offender a. Conditional on apprehension, they face an expected punishment x. In addition, apprehended offenders also face a probability of being referred to immigration officials p_D and a cost of deportation D.[17] We normalize the value of abstaining from crime to 0, so offenders commit an offense if the benefits outweigh the costs: $M - rax - rap_D D - c > 0$. The number of offenses is thus $O = G(M - rax - rap_D D)$.

Analogously, victims of crime face the choice of reporting the incident to the police. There is a uniform benefit from reporting the crime b as well as a victim-specific hassle cost of reporting h drawn from the cumulative distribution function $F(h)$ across victims. There is an additional cost of reporting the incident related to immigration enforcement: this cost is a function of the probability that an

[14] Moreover, not all detained individuals were immigrants; Kohli, Markowitz, and Chavez (2011) find that approximately 3,600 citizens were unlawfully detained by ICE via the SC program in 2008–2011.

[15] For example, "The Teens Trapped between a Gang and the Law," *New Yorker*, December 25, 2017.

[16] The U nonimmigrant status (U visa) program issues visas to victims of certain serious crimes who have suffered mental or physical abuse and are helpful in the investigation or prosecution of crime. This program is small in practice and excludes property crime victims. Only 10,000 visas are issued each year, and there is a backlog of over 325,000 visas with a waitlist of 5–10 years (see "A visa program created to help law enforcement puts immigrant victims at risk instead," *National Public Radio*, January 12, 2023).

[17] Noncitizen offenders can expect to serve two punishments: one through the criminal justice system (a period of incarceration in the United States) and one through the federal immigration system (detention and deportation).

individual is referred to immigration officials δp_D and the cost of deportation D.[18] Again, we normalize the value of not reporting to 0, so victims report an incident if the benefits outweigh the costs: $b - \delta p_D D - h > 0$. This rule implies a reporting probability $r = F(b - \delta p_D D)$.

The SC program increased information sharing between local law enforcement and federal immigration authorities, thereby raising the probability p_D that individuals would be referred to immigration officials. Notably, p_D enters into both a victim's reporting decision as well as an offender's decision to commit crime, and it thus affects both parties. An increase in p_D implies a higher cost of reporting offenses, and we thus expect the reporting probability r to unambiguously decline: $\frac{\partial r}{\partial p_D} < 0$.

In contrast, the prediction for O is ex ante ambiguous:

$$\frac{dO}{dp_D} = G'(\cdot)\Bigg[\underbrace{-\frac{\partial r}{\partial p_D}(ax + ap_D D)}_{\text{Lower Reporting} \uparrow \text{Crime}} \quad \underbrace{-raD}_{\text{Deterrence} \downarrow \text{Crime}}\Bigg] \lesseqgtr 0.$$

Intuitively, an increase in p_D increases the cost of offending, but the decline in reporting r among victims also lowers this same cost by decreasing the likelihood that crimes are detected by police. The impact of the SC program on public safety thus depends on which of these effects dominates and is an empirical question. While the overall effect on public safety is ambiguously signed, we would expect offending to increase for *non-Hispanic* offenders, who face a lower apprehension probability but minimal change in deportation risk (see Supplemental Appendix Section C.5). Finally, the sign of SC's impact on *reported* crime, $C = rO$, is also ambiguously signed and, crucially, may differ from the program's impact on criminal offending, O.

Our primary interest is in estimating how offending responds *directly* to a change in victim reporting, summarized by the elasticity $\epsilon_{O,r} = \frac{\partial O}{\partial r} \times \frac{r}{O}$. As we show in Supplemental Appendix C, we can calculate an upper bound for this (negative) elasticity using the ratio of the program's impacts on offending and victim reporting:

$$\frac{dO/O}{dp_D}\Bigg/\frac{dr/r}{dp_D} = \underbrace{\epsilon_{O,r}}_{\leq 0} + \underbrace{\frac{\epsilon_{O,p_D}}{\epsilon_{r,p_D}}}_{\geq 0}, \tag{1}$$

where $\epsilon_{x,y}$ generically reflects the partial derivative elasticity of x with respect to y. Because the direct effect of the change in deportation probability on offending is negative (given deterrence), as is the effect on victim reporting, the second term in the expression above is positive. Hence, our empirical estimate of this ratio is a biased-upward estimate of $\epsilon_{O,r}$.[19]

With this conceptual framework in mind, we now turn to estimating the program's impacts on victimization and victim reporting.

[18] The parameter $\delta \in [0,1]$ allows the probability of deportation to differ between victims and offenders. Importantly, δ incorporates a victim's belief about their likelihood of deportation, whether that likelihood is real or perceived.

[19] In Supplemental Appendix C, we also consider an extension where we allow the distribution of costs to offending $G(c)$ to respond to the policy. In this case, the ratio of the policy's impacts is no longer necessarily an upper bound on our estimand of interest, since the policy may directly induce more offending if the costs to offending decline (e.g., through worsening of labor market opportunities). We provide evidence in Section VII against the importance of changing economic conditions as a channel for the program's effects.

III. Data

A. *Data Sources*

Our primary dataset is the National Crime Victimization Survey (NCVS) administered by the Bureau of Justice Statistics (BJS) and the US Census Bureau. This survey is the nation's primary data source on victimizations and collects information from a nationally representative sample of approximately 240,000 persons each year. The NCVS encompasses records of serious crimes that are characterized by having a victim (namely violent and property crimes) and is distinct from administrative police records on reported crime collected by the FBI Uniform Crime Reports (UCR). Nevertheless, research conducted by criminologists and BJS statisticians has found a high degree of convergence between the NCVS and UCR for crimes reported to police, especially in urban and suburban areas and after the year 2000 (e.g., Morgan and Thompson 2022; Berg and Lauritsen 2016; Lauritsen, Rezey, and Heimer 2016).

The NCVS asks respondents whether they experienced a victimization in the prior six months and asks follow-up questions about each victimization incident, including whether they informed the police about the incident. These data thus allow us to measure changes in crime (i.e., victimizations) separately from changes in crime reporting behavior. We can also construct measures of *reported* crime rates, or the likelihood that an individual is both victimized *and* reports the crime, as a share of all individuals. We utilize the restricted-access version of the NCVS, available through the Census Bure Federal Statistical Research Data Centers, because this version includes the respondent's county of residence. For more details on the survey and its sample design, see Supplemental Appendix D.

Given the retrospective nature of the survey, we build a dataset at the person $\times$ year $\times$ month level corresponding to the years and months for which a respondent is answering. To construct the baseline sample, we first limit the sample to respondents residing in counties that are consistently included in the NCVS for the 2006–2015 survey waves. Following Alsan and Yang (2024), we also exclude southern border counties as well as counties in Massachusetts, Illinois, and New York. Enforcement began earlier in border counties and selection could have played a role in program activation in these locations (Cox and Miles 2015), whereas the latter three states resisted the implementation of the SC program. Our baseline sample also focuses on counties whose population in the 2000 census exceeded 100,000 individuals. Hispanic individuals are significantly more likely to live in these counties and accordingly, immigration enforcement tends to be concentrated in these areas.

Due to US Census Bureau disclosure rules, we cannot report the precise number of counties in our baseline sample. However, as a frame of reference, 458 counties in the United States meet these sample restrictions, representing 173 million individuals (61 percent of the national population), 24.3 million Hispanic individuals (69 percent of the Hispanic population), and 7.4 million noncitizen Hispanic individuals (73 percent of the noncitizen Hispanic population) based on population counts from the 2000 census (Manson et al. 2022). In robustness checks in Section VF, we consider the sensitivity of estimates to our sampling choices.

Information on the activation date of the SC program in each county comes from publicly available reports published by DHS. We supplement this information with records on ICE detainer requests and removals from the Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse (TRAC) at Syracuse University. Detainer data provide information on all ICE detainer requests from 2002–2015, including whether a detainer was "honored" (i.e., whether an individual was "booked into detention" by ICE). Unlike the information about detainers, removals data only pertain to removals that occurred as a result of the SC program and are thus only available post-treatment. We aggregate these data sources to construct measures of the number of overall detainer requests, the number of honored detainers, and the number of SC removals at the county $\times$ year $\times$ month level. Our preferred measure of enforcement intensity is honored detainers because it is available both before and after treatment and is more closely linked to deportation actions, as it only includes individuals who were transferred to ICE custody.[20]

We augment the analysis with local area characteristics. We use the 2000 census and American Community Survey via IPUMS for demographic and economic characteristics; Census Bureau population estimates; FBI Uniform Crime Reporting data; Urban Institute data on state and local immigration policies; MIT Election Data for election results; and Bureau of Labor Statistics data for unemployment rates. Finally, in Section VII, we utilize a novel collection of administrative micro-data from police departments across the United States to examine police behavior and arrestee characteristics (see Supplemental Appendix F for more details).

B. *Summary Statistics*

Table 1 shows that on average, Hispanic individuals have higher victimization rates than non-Hispanic individuals, mainly due to a higher likelihood of experiencing property crimes. Across crime incidents, Hispanic victims report incidents at modestly lower rates than non-Hispanic individuals. Finally, as has been shown in prior studies (e.g., Carr and Doleac 2018), there is significant under-reporting of incidents, with only 34 percent of crime incidents being reported to the police.

We preview our main results by plotting raw outcome means for the eight quarters before and after SC implementation, separately for Hispanic and non-Hispanic individuals. Panel A of Figure 2 shows that the reporting rate of Hispanic respondents declines following the launch of the program. At the same time, panel C of Figure 2 shows that the victimization rate of Hispanic respondents rises after the program implementation. Non-Hispanic individuals do not appear to have any post-treatment change in either outcome. Finally, panel E of Figure 2 shows that *reported* crime rates, or the likelihood that a person is both victimized and reports the crime, appear stable over time for both ethnicity groups, illustrating the fact that reported crime rates can mask concurrent opposing changes in victimization and reporting rates.

[20] ICE detainer requests do not necessarily lead to a deportation. Unfortunately, information from TRAC on detentions cannot be linked to the removals data. Nevertheless, consistent with prior research (Alsan and Yang 2024; Medina-Cortina 2022), Figure A.4 shows a strong, positive correlation (0.86) between county-level SC removals and honored detainers in the post-SC period.

Table 1—Summary Statistics of NCVS Sample, by Hispanic Ethnicity

	All respondents (*Person-months*)			Crime victims (*Incidents*)		
	All	Hispanic	Non-Hispanic	All	Hispanic	Non-Hispanic
White	0.66	0.00	0.78	0.62	0.00	0.74
Black	0.12	0.00	0.14	0.15	0.00	0.18
Hispanic	0.15	1.00	0.00	0.17	1.00	0.00
Female	0.53	0.52	0.53	0.52	0.50	0.52
Age	44.99	37.89	46.29	39.41	34.55	40.42
HS degree or less	0.45	0.67	0.41	0.45	0.63	0.42
Some college	0.25	0.19	0.26	0.31	0.25	0.32
BA or more	0.28	0.12	0.31	0.23	0.11	0.25
Student	0.17	0.22	0.16	0.21	0.23	0.21
Employed	0.56	0.56	0.56	0.60	0.61	0.59
Married	0.52	0.50	0.53	0.38	0.43	0.37
Urban resident	0.91	0.97	0.90	0.94	0.98	0.93
Rural resident	0.09	0.03	0.10	0.06	0.02	0.07
HH Inc. $<$ \$30k	0.17	0.26	0.15	0.26	0.30	0.25
HH Inc. \$30k–\$50k	0.15	0.20	0.14	0.17	0.20	0.16
HH Inc. \$50k–\$75k	0.13	0.12	0.13	0.11	0.11	0.12
HH Inc. $>$ \$75k	0.25	0.14	0.28	0.21	0.13	0.22
Victimized ($\times 100$)	0.86	0.96	0.84	100.00	100.00	100.00
Victimized: violent ($\times 100$)	0.15	0.16	0.15	18.05	15.97	18.48
Victimized: property ($\times 100$)	0.71	0.82	0.69	81.75	83.86	81.30
Reported to police ($\times 100$)	30.58	31.80	30.36	34.41	31.58	35.00
Persons	170,000	28,500	141,000	17,500	3,000	14,500
Observations	2,541,000	391,000	2,150,000	23,500	4,100	19,500

Notes: This table displays summary statistics for our baseline sample in the National Crime Victimization Survey (NCVS). The first three columns report summary statistics (averages) among NCVS respondents in the baseline sample (the dataset is at the person $\times$ year $\times$ month level corresponding to the years and months for which a respondent is answering). The final three columns report averages for individuals who have been victimized (the dataset is restricted to records of crime incidents). In all columns, measures of victimization and crime reporting have been multiplied by 100. All characteristics are denoted using indicator variables and missing values are counted as zeros. Observation numbers and estimates have been rounded following US Census Bureau disclosure guidelines.

IV. Empirical Strategy

Our empirical strategy leverages the differential timing of program implementation. Specifically, we estimate a difference-in-differences regression of the following form:

$$Y_{ict} = \beta_{\text{Post}} \text{SC}_{ct} + \mu_c + \delta_t + \epsilon_{ict}, \tag{2}$$

where Y_{ict} is an outcome variable for person i in county c at time t (month $\times$ year). SC_{ct} is an indicator variable equal to one if county c had implemented the SC program at time t. The terms μ_c and δ_t correspond to county and time fixed effects, respectively. The error term is ϵ_{ict} and standard errors are clustered at the county level. Throughout the analysis, we use person-level survey weights to maintain sample representativeness. The coefficient of interest is β_{Post}, which represents the program's impact on outcome Y in the two years after implementation.[21]

[21] To separately identify the two-year effect, we also include an additional indicator variable that is equal to one for all time periods beyond the two years after the program's launch.

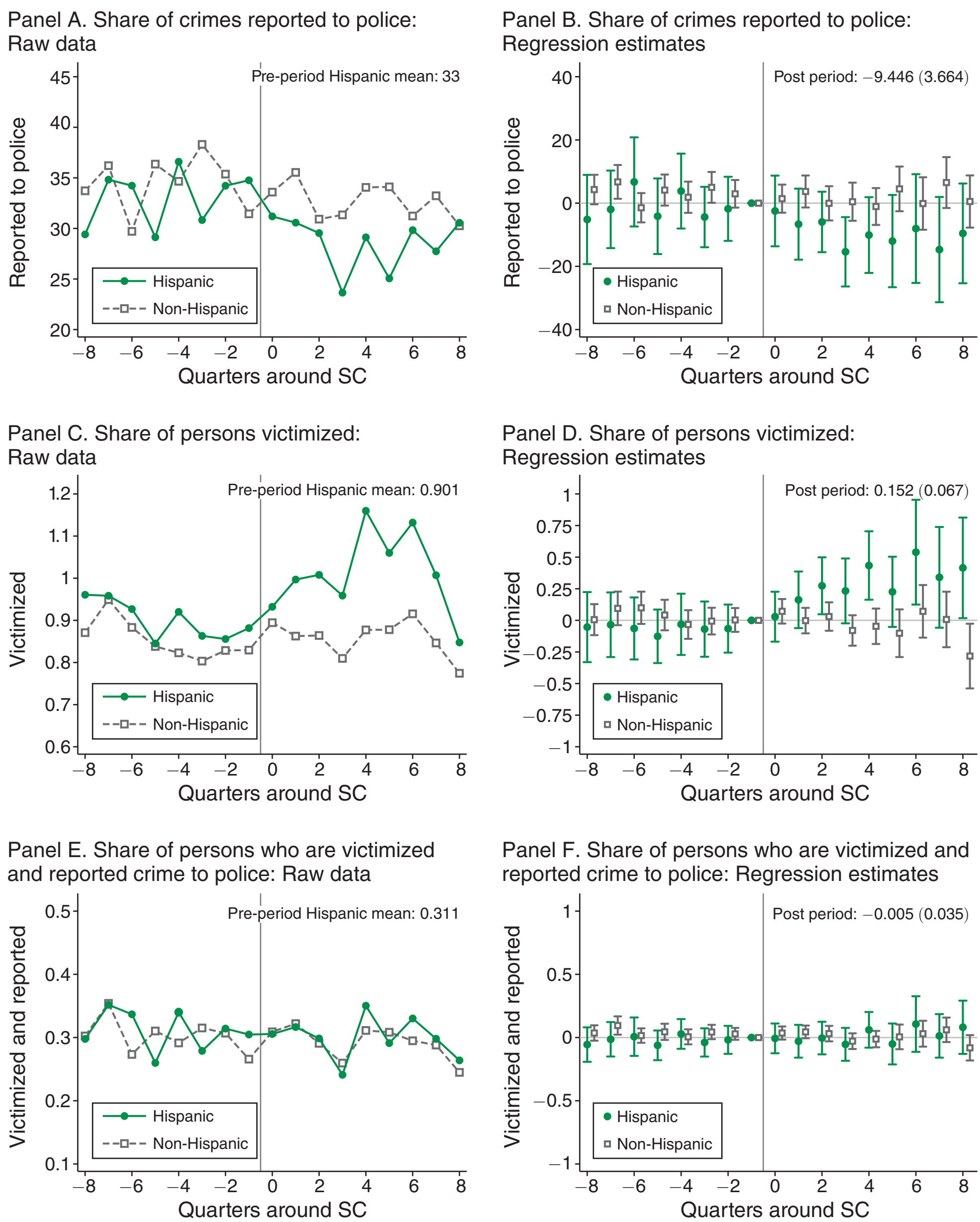

FIGURE 2. IMPACTS OF SECURE COMMUNITIES BY HISPANIC ETHNICITY

Notes: Panels A, C, and E plot the raw means of outcomes before and after the implementation of SC. The outcome is multiplied by 100 for ease of exposition. Panels B, D, and F plot the difference-in-differences estimates using equation (3) and report the β_{Post} estimate and corresponding standard error from equation (2). Standard errors are clustered at the county level. Estimates are weighted using NCVS person weights.

We also consider a fully dynamic version of this regression specification:

$$Y_{ict} = \sum_{\tau=-8}^{\tau=7} \beta_\tau \times \mathrm{SC}_{ct}^{\tau} + \mu_c + \delta_t + \epsilon_{ict} \tag{3}$$

where we denote $\tau = 0$ as the first quarter after SC activation for each county c, and we include event-time dummies SC_{ct}^{τ} to quantify the effect of the program for the eight quarters before and after the implementation of the program.[22] We omit the quarter before the program introduction, so that each β_τ coefficient measures the difference in outcome Y relative to $\tau = -1$.

We have two binary outcomes of interest: whether an individual is victimized and whether a victimization incident is reported to the police. The first outcome denotes whether an individual is victimized at time t among all survey respondents, where the unit of observation is a person-month. The second outcome denotes whether a victimization that occurred at time t was reported by the victim to the police, where the unit of observation is a crime incident record. In our main results, we also consider a third outcome: the likelihood that a person is victimized *and* reports the incident. This outcome is analogous to measures of reported crime rates available in administrative data. For ease of exposition, we multiply outcome variables by 100.

Throughout the paper, we estimate regressions separately for Hispanic and non-Hispanic individuals. We report and interpret estimates for all Hispanic respondents—including citizens and noncitizens—in accordance with prior work showing that Hispanic citizens also respond to enforcement policies due to fear that a family member or neighbor may be deported (Watson 2014; Alsan and Yang 2024). We additionally consider non-Hispanic respondents in order to quantify any public safety impacts of SC on this group.

The identifying assumption for interpreting the estimates as the causal effect of the SC program is that individuals of a given ethnicity in earlier-treated counties would have continued to trend similarly to individuals of the same ethnicity in later-treated counties in the absence of the program. We consider the plausibility of this assumption by plotting the raw data as well as the β_τ coefficients from equation (3).

A growing econometrics literature has documented issues with the standard ordinary least squares (OLS) approach to difference-in-differences regressions with two-way fixed effects (TWFE). The program we study has many features that correspond to the concerns raised in this literature. First, all counties in the United States implemented the program between October 2008 and January 2013. The universal rollout of the program means that a β_{Post} coefficient estimated via OLS will have a significant contribution from potentially undesirable comparisons using already-treated units to estimate the effect for later-treated units. Second, the rollout of the policy occurs over a relatively short time frame, meaning that in a TWFE model, already-treated counties will comprise a meaningful share of control counties shortly after implementing the program. Third, past studies (Alsan and Yang 2024; East et al. 2023) indicate that the SC program may have dynamic impacts that vary over time, which could cause the standard TWFE regression to place negative weight on later-treated time periods (Goodman-Bacon 2021). Fourth, program effects may be heterogeneous across counties and depend on factors such as demographic composition, which could lead to dynamic regression coefficients which do not identify the true time path of impacts (Sun and Abraham 2021).

[22] We use the first and last indicators as "book-ends," so that they are equal to one for all time periods before and after the two years around implementation.

Given these concerns, our baseline strategy follows Sun and Abraham (2021), using later-treated counties as the control units for counties treated earlier in time. We define the later-treated counties as the final 25 percent of counties to activate the program in the baseline sample (those that implemented the program after August of 2011). In Section V, we show that the results are robust to alternative definitions of later-treated counties, as well as to the estimators proposed in Borusyak, Jaravel, and Spiess (2024) and Callaway and Sant'Anna (2021). While the concerns highlighted above are important, in practice the results are also quite similar using the standard TWFE model.

V. Results

A. *Enforcement*: *Immigrant Detentions*

We first establish that Secure Communities did in fact increase enforcement intensity. Panel B of Figure 1 plots the average logged number of honored immigration detainer requests around the implementation of SC. Panel C then estimates equation (3) using the logged number of honored detainers as the outcome variable. This figure confirms that the program led to a large and sudden increase in immigrant detentions, consistent with prior work (Alsan and Yang 2024; Medina-Cortina 2022). Estimates using equation (2) suggest that SC increased county-level honored detainer requests by over 50 percent (Table A.2). If we instead use all detainer requests as the outcome variable, we find a similar increase of 40 percent.

B. *Willingness to Report Crimes to Police*

Having established that Secure Communities increased immigration enforcement, we now study the likelihood that a crime victim reports their incident to the police. Table 2 displays the estimates of equation (2) for Hispanic and non-Hispanic respondents, and panel B of Figure 2 plots the dynamic event-study estimates. Here, the unit of observation is a criminal incident, so the sample is restricted to individuals who were victimized, or $\approx 1\%$ of the respondent sample. The results show that Hispanic victims in treated and control counties had comparable trends in reporting behavior prior to SC's implementation, with a joint F-test failing to reject that the pre-period effects are equal to zero (F-test: 1.06, p-value: 0.392), thus providing support for the parallel trends assumption. After the introduction of SC, the likelihood that Hispanic victims report an incident to the police declines by 9.5 percentage points, or a 30 percent decline relative to the average reporting rate among Hispanics. In contrast to the sharp decline in Hispanic reporting, we find that SC had no impact on non-Hispanic reporting.

The central importance of victim reporting stems from its impact on offenders' eventual apprehension risk. In the notation of our framework in Section II, the likelihood of apprehension for offenders is the product of the probability that a victim reports the incident r and the probability that an arrest is made for a reported offense a (often termed the clearance rate). In Supplemental Appendix E, we present estimates of SC's impact on apprehension risk. Our point estimates indicate that the percent decline in the overall likelihood of apprehension is similar in magnitude to

Table 2—Effect of Secure Communities, by Hispanic Ethnicity

	β_{Post}	(SE)	Y mean	N
Panel A. Hispanic				
Victimized	0.152	(0.067)	0.96	391,000
Reported to police	−9.446	(3.664)	30.98	4,100
Victimized and reported	−0.005	(0.035)	0.31	391,000
Panel B. Non-Hispanic				
Victimized	0.003	(0.035)	0.87	2,150,000
Reported to police	−1.112	(1.343)	34.50	19,500
Victimized and reported	−0.002	(0.016)	0.31	2,150,000
Panel C. Total				
Victimized	0.030	(0.033)	0.88	2,541,000
Reported to police	−2.247	(1.247)	33.89	23,600
Victimized and reported	−0.001	(0.015)	0.31	2,541,000

Notes: This table reports difference-in-differences estimates using equation (2). The estimate β_{Post} and standard error correspond to an indicator variable equal to one in the eight quarters following the implementation of the SC program. This table considers the baseline sample of NCVS respondents and uses individuals in later-treated counties as the control group for estimating the treatment effects of Secure Communities on the outcomes of individuals in earlier-treated counties (Sun and Abraham 2021). Standard errors are clustered at the county level. Estimates are weighted using NCVS person weights to maintain sample representativeness. "Y mean" refers to the average of the outcome variable in that specification. All outcomes are multiplied by 100 for ease of exposition (scale 0 to 100). Observations have been rounded following US Census Bureau disclosure guidelines.

the decline in reporting, suggesting that reporting is the primary driver of the policy's impact on apprehension risk.

A decline in the likelihood of reporting crimes to the police is consistent with a general "chilling effect": individuals are afraid of interacting with law enforcement and are thus less likely to report victimizations. Indeed, in Table A.4, we analyze reasons that respondents provide for not reporting incidents to police, and we find that the entire increase in non-reporting is driven by reasons associated with fear or mistrust of law enforcement. The findings in this section are consistent with work that finds that Hispanic crime reporting increases following reforms that made the policy environment friendlier toward immigrants (Comino, Mastrobuoni, and Nicolò 2020; Jácome 2022). The results also complement work documenting other Hispanic behavioral changes due to SC, including lower public assistance program participation (Watson 2014; Alsan and Yang 2024) and fewer workplace complaints (Grittner and Johnson 2022).

Finally, we note that the decline in victim reporting occurred gradually over the first year after SC implementation, whereas immigrant detentions increased immediately (Figure 1). We interpret this pattern as evidence of immigrant communities learning about heightened enforcement over time. Consistent with this interpretation, Alsan and Yang (2024) studies changes in deportation-related Google searches following SC and finds that the volume of searches rises gradually over the first two years following program activation.[23]

[23] Given data limitations, we cannot distinguish the extent to which immigrant communities learned about heightened enforcement by directly witnessing detentions in their neighborhoods versus through community networks and other local efforts to spread awareness.

C. *Victimization*

Next, we examine the impact of Secure Communities on public safety. Panel D of Figure 2 plots the dynamic event-study estimates for criminal victimizations. The figure highlights that Hispanic and non-Hispanic respondents living in treated counties (early-treated counties) had comparable trends in victimization rates to those living in control counties (later-treated counties) prior to SC. Again, we fail to reject that the pre-period event-study coefficients for Hispanics are equal to zero (F-test: 0.425, p-value: 0.886). After SC, Hispanic individuals become 0.15 percentage points, or 16 percent, *more* likely to become victims of crime relative to Hispanic individuals in the comparison group. By contrast, when we consider the victimization rates of non-Hispanic individuals, we find precise null effects.

Together, these results run contrary to the program's explicit goal of improving public safety. In fact, the results imply that levels of public safety *worsened* among Hispanic individuals following changes in enforcement. A back-of-the-envelope calculation suggests that SC resulted in 875,000 additional crimes against Hispanics in the two years after program implementation among our sample of counties. Under the assumption that the results apply nationwide, the estimated effect translates to 1.3 million additional crimes.[24]

What does the increase in victimizations among Hispanics imply for overall public safety? If we pool all survey respondents and run an analogous specification, we find a victimization increase of around 3.4 percent, though this estimate is not statistically significant. These findings emphasize the importance of using data sources that identify a victim's ethnicity to detect changes in crime, especially in contexts where one racial or ethnic group is disproportionately affected by a policy change. Overall, the full-population estimates rule out declines in victimization larger than 3.9 percent, indicating that the policy did not generate meaningful improvements in aggregate public safety.[25]

D. Reported Crime Rates

Our main finding—that the SC program increased crime against Hispanics—stands in stark contrast to a substantial body of literature analyzing the program using data on crimes *reported to the police* (Miles and Cox 2014; Treyger, Chalfin, and Loeffler 2014; Hines and Peri 2019). To reconcile this discrepancy, we combine our two primary outcomes and estimate SC's impact on the likelihood of being victimized *and* reporting a crime.

Panel F of Figure 2 shows that the reported crime rates of both Hispanic and non-Hispanic respondents exhibit no change around SC's introduction. The null result for Hispanics arises because the reported crime rate masks two opposing

[24] We calculate this number by multiplying the monthly victimization effect by 24 (months) and by the Hispanic population (35.3 million).

[25] A useful benchmark for interpreting this 3.9 percent lower bound is to ask what public safety impact would be expected based solely on the program's increase in deportations. In Section VIID, we perform this calculation by combining our estimated deportation effect with an estimate from Johnson and Raphael (2012) of the crime impact of incarceration; we predict a 0.109 percentage point (12 percent) crime decline, well outside the confidence interval for SC's actual crime impact.

effects: an increase in victimization and a decrease in reporting. These null effects on the rate of reported victimization mirror previous findings that concluded SC had no meaningful impact on public safety.[26] However, our results underscore that mis-measuring crime—by relying on data of *reported* crime—can lead to incorrect conclusions about the program's true impact.

In sum, our findings overturn the prevailing consensus on the impact of the SC program, while providing a rationale for why the existing literature has failed to detect a crime-related effect from this policy. More broadly, these results highlight the importance of accounting for reporting behavior when estimating changes in public safety, particularly when studying policies that may influence both an offender's incentives to commit crimes and a victim's incentives to report them.

E. *Effects by Crime Type*

Last, we investigate violent and property victimizations separately. Table A.5 shows that the reporting effect is primarily driven by a large, significant (34 percent) decline in Hispanics' willingness to report property offenses, with no analogous significant decline in the likelihood of reporting violent offenses. These results suggest that heightened enforcement dissuaded Hispanics from contacting police for nonviolent incidents. We similarly find that the increase in victimization is driven by a 15 percent increase in property crimes against Hispanics. While our point estimates show a similarly sized 15 percent increase in violent crimes, we are under-powered to identify a statistically significant effect on this relatively rare outcome.[27]

F. *Robustness Results*

In Supplemental Appendix B, we conduct a series of robustness checks to verify the stability of our main findings. The results are presented in Tables B.1–B.3 and in Figures B.1–B.6. We vary the sample construction, the definitions of earlier- versus later-treated counties, and the regression specification, including estimating two-way fixed effects, alternative difference-in-differences estimators, models with linear time trends, and triple-difference specifications that use non-Hispanics as a control group. In all cases, the results are consistent with our baseline estimates. In addition, we provide evidence that our difference-in-differences design is not masking nationwide program impacts occurring with the first activation date.

We also address concerns that our findings could be driven by survey response bias, ethnic reclassification, or changing respondent or crime composition. Using NCVS survey design features, we test for program impacts on response rates and ethnic self-identification, finding minimal effects and showing that even under worst-case

[26] Table A.3 confirms these findings using agency-level UCR data that aligns with our sampling restrictions and empirical approach. Like previous work, we find small, mostly statistically insignificant, effects of SC on reported crime (the even-numbered columns include agency-specific linear time trends for greater comparability to prior work which includes these controls).

[27] A concurrent paper in criminology (Baumer and Xie 2023) uses logistic regressions in the NCVS to simultaneously estimate the effect of SC, the 287(g) program, and sanctuary policies on violent victimizations, controlling for time-varying and time-invariant individual, neighborhood, and county attributes. That paper finds that SC and 287(g) agreements are associated with an 86 percent and 111 percent increase in violent victimizations of Latinos, respectively. We attribute the difference in our findings to the differing empirical strategies employed.

assumptions, these factors could account for only a small share of the estimated victimization increase. Additional analyses that restrict to "always-responders," incorporate person fixed effects, or predict victimization and reporting based on pre-policy characteristics likewise yield similar conclusions.

VI. Heterogeneity

A. *Neighborhood Characteristics*

We first consider whether individuals who live in neighborhoods with high shares of Hispanic residents have differing treatment effects. We use a respondent's census tract to estimate equation (2) for subsamples of respondents living in neighborhoods with progressively higher shares of Hispanic and noncitizen Hispanic residents (i.e., by sequentially restricting the sample to those above the fiftieth, seventy-fifth, and ninetieth percentiles of the corresponding tract-level distributions).

Panels A and B in Figure A.6 show results for Hispanics. Because most Hispanic respondents live in areas with high shares of Hispanic residents, victimization and reporting effects are relatively constant as the neighborhood resident share of Hispanics (or noncitizen Hispanics) increases, though the victimization increase is moderately larger in neighborhoods with the highest shares of noncitizen Hispanics.

A more striking pattern emerges in panels C and D for non-Hispanic individuals. The likelihood of reporting crimes to police decreases, and victimization generally increases, as neighborhoods become more Hispanic (or noncitizen Hispanic). The reporting effects show a reduced willingness to report crimes by non-Hispanic victims in Hispanic neighborhoods, possibly due to concerns about rising deportation risks for their neighbors.[28] The victimization effects are consistent with offenders targeting Hispanic neighborhoods after the policy—potentially because apprehension risk declined with reduced reporting—thereby increasing victimizations of non-Hispanics in these areas.

Given these results, we return to the baseline sample and consider how results for non-Hispanics change if we allow their geographic composition to mirror that of Hispanics. Specifically, we reestimate the baseline specification for non-Hispanics but reweight respondents to reflect the county composition of Hispanic respondents. We find an 8 percent increase in victimizations for non-Hispanic respondents and no change in their reporting behavior (row 12 in Table B.2 and Figure B.2). These results suggest that although the decline in public safety was most concentrated among Hispanic individuals, non-Hispanic residents in counties with large Hispanic populations also experienced an increase in victimization.

[28] Another interpretation of these reporting declines is that non-Hispanics residing in Hispanic neighborhoods are disproportionately likely to be unauthorized themselves. Using tract-level data from the 2005–2009 ACS, we instead find a *negative* tract-level correlation between the noncitizen non-Hispanic share and the noncitizen Hispanic share within counties, which runs counter to this interpretation.

B. *County Characteristics*

We first document variation in impacts by estimating equation (2) separately for each earlier-treated cohort of counties (i.e., counties that activated the program in the same year-month), using Hispanic respondents in later-treated counties as the comparison group. Figure A.7 displays the distribution of treatment effects. Among 31 cohorts, 30 have negative reporting effects and 28 have positive victimization effects. The distribution of reporting effects is relatively narrow, clustered around a 10 percentage point decline. These patterns imply that the main results are not driven by a few select counties or cohorts.

These distributions provide a natural motivation for exploring whether county-level characteristics are predictive of the magnitude of program impacts. Table A.6 first assesses whether the intensity of enforcement varied across counties with different characteristics, using ICE removals in the two-year post-period to measure enforcement. Column 1 shows that counties with a higher share of noncitizen Hispanic residents have higher removals per capita, or greater *total* enforcement. We next explore whether the victimization effects are likewise a function of county characteristics. We return to the baseline NCVS sample and estimate regressions similar to equation (2), but allowing the effect of β_{Post} to vary with county characteristics (columns 3–5). Counties with higher noncitizen Hispanic shares—which had higher levels of total enforcement—have larger victimization effects.[29] For reporting, we find minimal evidence that county characteristics predict differences in the treatment effects among Hispanics. These findings are perhaps unsurprising given the limited variation in the decline in Hispanic reporting across cohorts of counties (Figure A.7).

VII. Reduced Reporting as the Key Driver of Higher Victimization

We have presented evidence that Secure Communities both decreased the Hispanic crime reporting rate and increased Hispanic victimization, impacts which may be directly linked. Since Becker (1968), economists have recognized that offender behavior depends on the probability of apprehension, which is implicitly tied to victim reporting. However, in addition to affecting crime reporting behavior, the SC program led to an increase in deportation risk for immigrant arrestees, as well as multiple economic and social changes within Hispanic communities (e.g., East et al. 2023; Medina-Cortina 2022; Amuedo-Dorantes, Arenas-Arroyo, and Sevilla 2018), each of which may have had an impact on public safety. In this section, we provide several pieces of evidence pointing to the reporting decline as the main driver of increased victimization. We conclude by deriving and discussing our estimate of the elasticity of offending to victim reporting.

[29] We also consider the share of removals from felony offenses, reflecting "targeted" enforcement toward serious offenders. Counties with higher shares of Hispanics tend to have more targeted enforcement, which may suggest that, conditional on the noncitizen Hispanic share (the population subject to enforcement), Hispanic voters may have a preference for targeted enforcement. These counties also have lower victimization effects, providing suggestive evidence that victimization could potentially decrease (or increase less) when serious offenders are targeted.

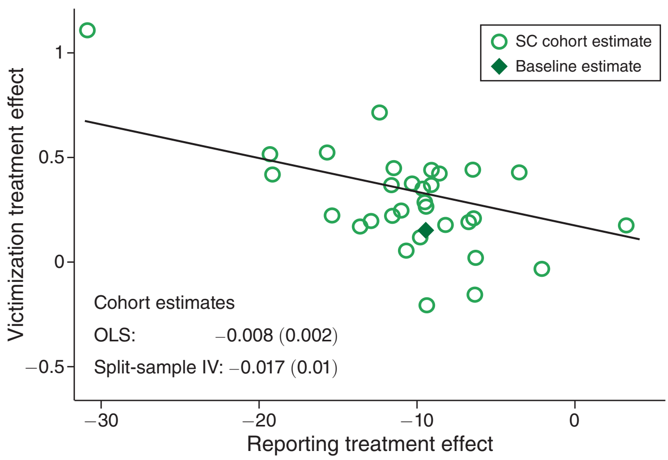

Figure 3. Victimization Effect versus Reporting Effect, by Secure Communities Cohort

Notes: This figure plots the victimization treatment effects against the reporting treatment effects separately for each SC cohort. A cohort refers to counties that activated SC in the same year and month. Each circle reflects a cohort's β_{Post} estimate from equation (2) for the victimization and reporting outcomes. The diamond marker refers to the estimates that group all cohorts (see Table 2). The sample of counties utilized in this figure follows the NCVS sample restrictions described in Section III and we utilize later-treated counties as the control group for estimating the treatment effects of SC in earlier-treated counties (Sun and Abraham 2021). The figure reports the coefficient and standard error of a regression of the cohort-specific victimization treatment effect on the corresponding reporting treatment effect. "OLS" reports the coefficient of a regression of victimization cohort effects on the corresponding reporting cohort effects. Next, we randomly partition the sample into two parts and estimate cohort-specific reporting and victimization treatment effects in both sample partitions to address the joint determination of outcomes. "Split-sample IV" estimates a stacked regression of one partition's victimization cohort effects on that partition's own reporting cohort effects, instrumented by the other partition's reporting cohort effects. The plotted line corresponds to the "Split-Sample IV" estimates. Both of these models are weighted by the inverse square of the standard error of victimization effects.

A. *Relationship between Victimization and Reporting Effects*

We begin by showing that counties with larger crime reporting declines experienced larger victimization increases, using the cohort-level treatment effects among Hispanic individuals discussed in Section VIB. Figure 3 shows a pronounced negative relationship between these outcomes, and we estimate the slope of this negative relationship in two ways.

First, we estimate a bivariate regression of estimated cohort-level victimization treatment effects on reporting treatment effects. This regression yields a coefficient of −0.008, significant at the 1 percent level. Next, we randomly split the baseline sample into two partitions and instrument for the reporting effect in one partition using the analogous estimate from the alternate partition. This split-sample approach addresses two concerns in the simple OLS regression: (i) that the victimization and reporting effects are estimated in the same sample, which could induce a spurious correlation, and (ii) that the cohort-level reporting effects are measured with error, which could attenuate the estimated coefficient. Using this IV strategy, we find a larger negative coefficient of −0.017, significant at the 10 percent level, suggesting that this approach corrects for measurement error in the OLS estimation. We overlay the regression line from this preferred split-sample approach in Figure 3. The slope of the line suggests that for a 10 percentage point decline in reporting we would expect to see a 0.17 percentage point increase in the victimization rate, very similar to the baseline findings. This pronounced negative relationship is consistent with victim reporting being a key input into public safety.

B. *Changes in Police Behavior*

A competing hypothesis for the increase in victimization is that Secure Communities influenced police behavior in ways that contributed to higher crime rates. Recall that the program primarily operated through fingerprinting in county jails, which are almost always managed by county sheriffs rather than municipal police departments. Nevertheless, if police effectiveness declined or if officers reduced their patrols in response to the program, these shifts could have led to an increase in crime rates independent of the decline in reporting. In this subsection, we examine this possibility using a range of data sources.

We start by examining crime clearance rates, which reflect the likelihood that a reported crime is solved by police (typically resulting in an arrest) and thus serve as a proxy for the arrest rate of reported crimes (a in the notation of our framework in Section II). Police effectiveness in solving crimes could decline with SC if, for example, witness cooperation decreases or officers become more detached from Hispanic neighborhoods. Conversely, police effectiveness could improve if officers have more time and resources to focus on crime-solving due to a potential reduction in the number of reported crimes requiring investigation.[30]

We investigate clearance rates in two ways in Table 3. First, we use the NCVS to calculate the share of crime incidents reported to police that result in an arrest. We find no significant change in the likelihood of arrest for reported incidents. The point estimate for Hispanic victims implies a 22 percent reduction; however, this estimate is quite noisy and imprecise (p-value $= 0.48$). This finding is important because it implies that police effectiveness did not decline for cases with Hispanic victims or respond differentially by victim ethnicity. Second, we use UCR data to examine whether SC affected clearance rates for serious crimes. Again, we find no evidence that SC changed police crime-solving effectiveness.

To further explore potential changes in police behavior, we manually collected and harmonized administrative data on 911 calls to municipal police departments across the country for the period 2006–2011; we provide information on these data in Supplemental Appendix F. For the subset of cities for which we observe time stamps in the 911 call data, we calculate the log of the average time (in seconds) for a call to be assigned to a police officer. This measure is a proxy for the efficiency of police responses and the availability of patrol officers to be assigned to calls. We geocode all call records, allowing us to examine police response changes in census tracts with differing Hispanic populations. We designate tracts as "Hispanic tracts" if the Hispanic population share is above the ninetieth percentile of the tract-level Hispanic share distribution. We then estimate a version of equation (2) at the census tract $\times$ year-month level, and find no changes in police response times, overall or

[30] Clearance rates could also increase if the composition of reported incidents becomes more severe and shifts to crimes with higher clearance rates. See Supplemental Appendix C for further discussion.

Table 3—Effect of Secure Communities on Police Behavior

	β_{Post}	(SE)	Y mean	N
Panel A. Clearance rate among reported crimes				
1. NCVS				
All victims	0.066	(1.224)	9.61	23,600
Hispanic victims	−2.002	(2.812)	8.97	4,100
Non-Hispanic victims	0.261	(1.436)	9.74	19,500
2. UCR				
Index crimes	−0.052	(0.321)	20.00	13,098
Property crimes	0.080	(0.277)	16.59	13,098
Violent crimes	0.102	(0.918)	45.42	13,098
Panel B. Police response time				
All tracts	−0.144	(0.400)	4.94	23,836
Hispanic tracts	0.090	(0.206)	3.68	3,540
Non-Hispanic tracts	−0.150	(0.406)	5.16	20,296

Notes: This table reports difference-in-differences estimates using equation (2). Panel A reports changes in clearance rates using two datasets. The first set of results uses the baseline NCVS sample restricted to victimizations that are reported to the police. The outcome measures whether an arrest is made for a criminal victimization. The second set of results uses the FBI's Uniform Crime Reports (Kaplan 2021a). The sample and estimation are analogous to those in Table A.3 and use the share of crimes that were cleared as the outcome variable. Panel B uses administrative microdata collected from police departments across the country, as described in Supplemental Appendix F. Police response time refers to the logged average seconds to dispatch. The unit of observation is at the tract-year-month level, and regressions include city × county and year × month fixed effects. Tracts are weighted by their 2005–2009 population (Manson et al. 2022). In all regressions, the sample is restricted to meet the sampling criteria described in Section III. The regressions use later-treated counties as the control group for estimating the treatment effects of SC on the outcomes of counties treated earlier in time (Sun and Abraham 2021). Standard errors are clustered at the county level.

in Hispanic neighborhoods, suggesting that patrol patterns and officer availability remain largely unchanged after the policy.

Taken together, these findings provide no evidence that police are pulling back or becoming less effective in response to SC, thus ruling out changes in police behavior as a main driver of the observed increase in victimization.[31]

C. *Economic Distress*: *Hispanic Composition of Arrestees*

Prior work has documented that Secure Communities affected the labor supply and wages of immigrant workers (East et al. 2023; Ali, Brown, and Herbst 2024), which could have led to an increase in criminal activity. Specifically, if the increase in crime stems from Hispanic individuals having worse economic conditions, then we would expect the composition of offenders to be relatively *more* Hispanic after SC.

[31] Our results also point against racial animus as an alternative channel for the victimization increase. Chiefly, we find an increase in *non-Hispanic* victimization in counties and neighborhoods with larger Hispanic populations (Table B.2, Figures B.2 and A.6), suggesting that the increase in offending is not strictly determined by ethnicity, and instead could be related to location-level changes in the likelihood of offender apprehension. Further, we do not find evidence of larger increases in Hispanic victimization in counties with a higher Republican vote share (Table A.6), where anti-immigrant sentiments are likely more common (see, for example, Afrouzi, Arteaga, and Weisburst (2024) and "Americans Still Value Immigration, but Have Concerns," *Gallup*, July 13, 2023).

While the NCVS is uniquely able to disentangle impacts on victimization and crime reporting separately by respondent ethnicity, it does not provide thorough offender information. Most victims in the survey are unable to provide information about the offender, and ethnicity information about offenders is limited.[32] Indeed, lack of information on offender characteristics is a pervasive challenge in the economics of crime literature (Doleac 2023).

We circumvent this challenge by collecting micro-data on arrest records from municipal police departments for 2006–2011, data which are similar to the 911 call data used above to measure police response times. Each arrest observation records the date of the arrest as well as basic demographic information on the arrested individual. Crucially, we observe Hispanic arrestee ethnicity in 37 cities, as well as the location of each incident, allowing us to investigate program impacts on arrestee composition separately by neighborhood type.

Our goal is to understand the impact of SC on the ethnic composition of arrestees, applying our baseline estimation strategy of equation (2). In this analysis, the unit of observation is a census tract in a given year-month. Because we do not observe victim ethnicity in these data, we again split our analysis by neighborhood ethnic composition. Examining effects *within* Hispanic neighborhoods allows us to investigate changes in arrestee composition, holding fixed the characteristics of potential victims. In order to interpret our effects on arrestee composition as reflecting impacts on *offender* composition, we must assume that neither victim reporting nor police clearance rates vary by offender ethnicity.

The top panel of Table 4 presents changes in overall, Hispanic, and non-Hispanic per capita arrest rates for the full sample as well as separately for Hispanic and non-Hispanic tracts. Panel B then uses these estimates to calculate the change in the share of arrestees who are Hispanic. The outcome mean shows that the Hispanic arrestee share is lower than the Hispanic resident share, perhaps due to immigrants' lower criminality relative to the US born (Abramitzky et al. 2024). Across all tract types, the Hispanic share declines after SC. In Hispanic tracts, there is a 2.3 p.p decline off a base of 47 percent, or a 5 percent decline.

In sum, these results indicate that the composition of arrestees (and offenders, given the assumptions above) changed after the launch of SC to become *less* Hispanic. These findings are inconsistent with changes in economic conditions driving the increase in crime.

D. *Deportations and Other Economic/Social Changes*

Next, we use a mediation analysis to directly decompose the victimization increase into components explained by SC's impacts on deportations and other economic and social outcomes. To do so, we estimate SC's impact on these outcomes and then ask: how large of a victimization response would we expect to see based on the elasticities of crime with respect to each of these outcomes from the existing

[32] For violent crimes (17 percent of victimizations), 40 percent of crimes were committed by strangers (Harrell 2012). For theft and larceny, 84 percent of victims reported that the offender was a stranger or they did not know the number of offenders (Bureau of Justice Statistics 2024). The NCVS added offender ethnicity in 2012, preventing us from learning about Hispanic ethnicity during our sample period.

Table 4—Effect of Secure Communities (SC) on Arrest Composition, Using Police Administrative Data

	All tracts			Hispanic tracts			Non-Hispanic tracts		
	β_{Post}	(SE)	$\overline{Y}$	β_{Post}	(SE)	$\overline{Y}$	β_{Post}	(SE)	$\overline{Y}$
Panel A. Arrests per capita									
Hispanic	−0.033	(0.016)	0.59	−0.088	(0.072)	1.37	−0.010	(0.009)	0.34
Non-Hispanic	0.020	(0.098)	2.67	0.018	(0.124)	1.85	0.016	(0.099)	2.93
Total	−0.013	(0.108)	3.26	−0.070	(0.188)	3.22	0.006	(0.106)	3.27
Panel B. Implied arrest share									
Hispanic share	−0.013	(0.007)	0.208	−0.023	(0.013)	0.473	−0.005	(0.003)	0.123
Observations		187,738			49,914			137,824	
Number of cities		37			20			37	
Tract share Hispanic		0.30			0.74			0.15	

Notes: This table reports difference-in-differences estimates using equation (2) and micro-data from police administrative records, as described in Section VIIC. In panel A, the outcome is arrests per 1,000 population. In panel B, we use the estimates from panel A to calculate the change in the share of arrested individuals that are Hispanic. Standard errors are calculated using the Delta Method. The unit of observation is at the tract-year-month level, and regressions include city × county and year × month fixed effects. Tracts are weighted by their 2005–2009 population (Manson et al. 2022). In all regressions, the sample is restricted to meet the sampling criteria described in Section III. The regressions use later-treated counties as the control group for estimating the treatment effects of SC on the outcomes of counties treated earlier in time (Sun and Abraham 2021). Standard errors are clustered at the county level. $\overline{Y}$ refers to the pre-period average of the outcome variable in that specification. "Number of cities" refers to the number of cities represented in the regression. "Tract share Hispanic" refers to the average Hispanic population share in the corresponding tracts.

literature? We summarize the approach and results here, and point the reader to Supplemental Appendix G for more detail.

Framework.—We consider a set of outcomes that, while parsimonious, capture the fact that SC impacted both social and economic outcomes in Hispanic communities. We consider deportations stemming from increased enforcement; the employment-to-population ratio and logged hourly wage of low-educated foreign-born Hispanics (following East et al. 2023); and the share of Hispanic household heads that are female. All of these outcomes are impacted by SC and could have consequences for victimization.

We follow the mediation analysis framework and notation of Heckman, Pinto, and Savelyev (2013) and Fagereng, Mogstad, and Rønning (2021) to model how victimization relates to this set of outcomes (i.e., "mediators") impacted by SC. We index treatment status by the subscript 0 or 1 and observed mediators by the superscript j. We can decompose the overall effect of SC on victimization, V, into a component explained by observed mediators θ^j and a "residual" term:

$$\mathrm{E}\left[V_1 - V_0\right] = \underbrace{\sum_{j \in \mathcal{J}_p} \alpha^j \mathrm{E}\left[\theta_1^j - \theta_0^j\right]}_{\substack{\text{Treatment effect due} \\ \text{to observed mediators}}} + \underbrace{\mathrm{E}\left[\tau_1 - \tau_0\right]}_{\substack{\text{Treatment effect due} \\ \text{to unobserved mediators}}} \tag{4}$$

The left-hand side of this equation is the overall victimization effect of SC, reported in Table 2. The goal is to quantify the first expression on the right-hand side. To do so, we need estimates of $\mathrm{E}[\theta_1^j - \theta_0^j]$, measuring the effect of SC on each mediator variable, as well as estimates of α^j, measuring the effect of each mediator on victimization.

Results.—We begin by estimating the effect of SC on the mediators, corresponding to the $\mathrm{E}\left[\theta_1^j - \theta_0^j\right]$ terms in equation (4). For the effect of SC on deportations, we use our estimate of the increase in honored ICE detainers (or transfers to ICE custody) from Table A.2. For the remaining mediators, we estimate SC impacts using equation (2) at the yearly level and our baseline set of counties in the 2005–2014 annual American Community Surveys (ACS). Column 3 of Table G.2 reports the results, indicating county-level declines in employment and wages as well as an increase in the share of household heads that are female.

Next, we calculate the effects of the mediators on victimization (i.e., the α^j terms) by using existing elasticities from the literature that link these mediators to crime rates. Specifically, we use estimates from Johnson and Raphael (2012); Gould, Weinberg, and Mustard (2002); and Glaeser and Sacerdote (1999) to calculate the elasticities of crime with respect to each mediator (column 1 of Table G.2). We choose to borrow estimates of α^j from the literature, rather than estimate them from our own data, because we do not have separate sources of exogenous variation for the mediators in our sample; in contrast, the studies we consult all use instruments to estimate the causal effect of these mediators on crime. Throughout this analysis, we borrow elasticities that use reported crime as the outcome, and we thus assume that the mediators do not affect reporting behavior when conducting these calculations.

The results from this decomposition exercise, shown in Figure 4 and the final column of Table G.2, offer three main takeaways. First, the negative bar corresponding to deportations suggests that the isolated effect of removing individuals is expected to reduce crime. The direction of this effect is consistent with the key aim of the SC program, that by raising the risk of detention and deportation for immigrants who commit crimes, the program would deter and incapacitate offenders.[33] Second, although SC impacted other labor market and demographic outcomes that are related to crime, their predicted effect on victimization—based on elasticities from prior work—is negligible. Put differently, the elasticity of crime with respect to these mediators would need to be significantly larger than the elasticities from prior work in order for these mediators to account for the increase in victimization. We thus conclude that demographic and economic responses to SC, while important outcomes in their own right, are not the primary drivers of the observed increase in Hispanic victimization.

Third, the mediation analysis reveals a notable positive "residual" effect. Since we have accounted for SC's impact on deportation, demographic, and economic responses, we interpret this positive residual as capturing the expected increase in victimization due to the decline in reporting. As further validation, the final bar of Figure 4 then compares the residual effect to the change in victimization we would have predicted based on the observed decline in reporting (Table 2) and the implied elasticity of offending to reporting from the cross-cohort analysis (Figure 3). The similarity in magnitudes between our baseline estimate of increased victimization (0.152), the mediator-adjusted residual effect (0.204), and the implied increase from

[33] To estimate the effect of deportations on crime, we use Johnson and Raphael's (2012) estimate of the crime impact of incarceration. Their estimand of interest is the treatment effect of changing the stock of prisoners, which jointly captures the incapacitation and deterrence impacts of incarceration. Their estimate is thus particularly suitable for our setting, where SC incapacitated offenders through deportation and possibly deterred potential offenders.

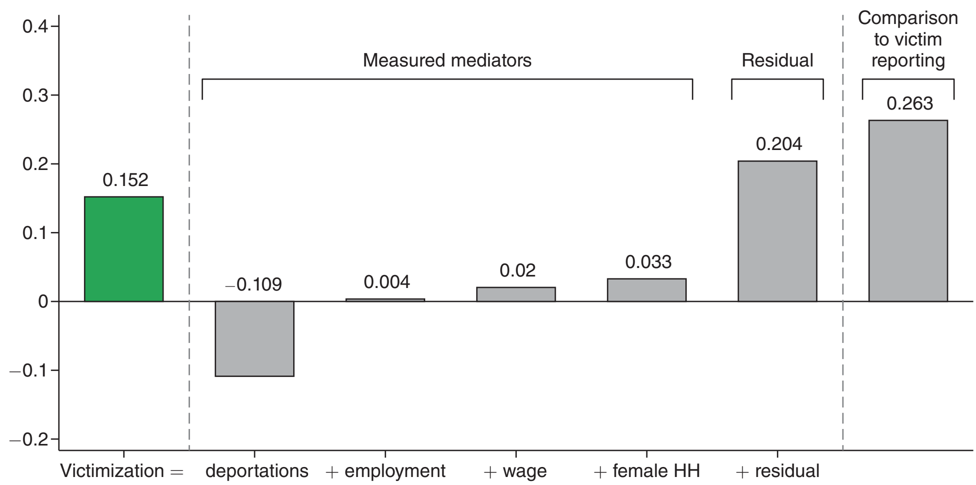

FIGURE 4. DECOMPOSING VICTIMIZATION INCREASE INTO VARIOUS COMPONENTS

Notes: This figure presents estimates from the mediation analysis outlined in Section VIID and depicted in Table G.2. The left-most estimate corresponds to the effect of SC on crime victimization (Table 2). The remaining bars depict the predicted effect of each mediator on victimization. The effect of deportations on victimization uses estimates from Table A.2. We estimate the effect of SC on the other mediators using the 2005–2014 American Community Surveys. "Residual" refers to the part of the total victimization effect that cannot be explained by the four mediators. The final bar depicts the implied effect of reporting on victimization using our reporting effect from the NCVS (Table 2) and our cohort-level victimization-to-reporting relationship (Figure 3). For more details on these calculations, see Supplemental Appendix G.

the reporting decline using the cross-cohort analysis (0.263) all indicate that the decline in victim reporting is the primary driver of the increase in victimization.

Finally, in Supplemental Appendix Figure G.1 we compare our predicted effect on victimization to what would be expected using several estimates from the literature on the relationship between reporting and offending. Note that this comparison is suggestive, as existing estimates pertain to specific offender populations (e.g., perpetrators of domestic violence). Nonetheless, it underscores that, if anything, our observed decline in reporting, combined with prior estimates from the literature, would have predicted an even larger effect on victimization than the effect we observe.

E. *Elasticity of Offending to Victim Reporting*

Using the findings from this section, we can now calculate the implied elasticity of offending to reporting in three ways. First, assuming that victimization increased *solely* because of reduced reporting, our baseline estimates imply an elasticity of -0.59. Second, if we use the mediation estimates to "residualize" the victimization effect of the components explained by deportation and social/economic changes, we estimate an elasticity of -0.79.[34] Third, we can use our cohort-level estimates from Section VIIA and conclude that the elasticity is -1.02.[35] Since deportations are

[34] Our residualized estimate of the victimization effect is $\mathrm{E}[V_1 - V_0] - \sum_{j \in \tilde{\mathcal{J}}_p} \alpha^j \mathrm{E}[\theta_1^j - \theta_0^j]$, where $\tilde{\mathcal{J}}$ consists of the four measured mediators.

[35] Each elasticity relies on different assumptions. The first assumes SC impacted victimization solely through reporting. The second assumes our mediators account for all non-reporting impacts of SC on victimization. The third assumes that cohort-level program impacts on reporting are uncorrelated with cohort-level program impacts on other channels that may impact victimization.

expected to reduce crime, it is unsurprising that our first elasticity estimate, which does not account for the program's deportation impact, is less negative than the residualized elasticity and the cohort-level elasticity. This finding accords with equation (1), which shows that an elasticity constructed from our baseline estimates provides an upper bound on the (negative) elasticity of offending to victim reporting.[36]

While our preceding analysis focused on accounting for the various channels beyond reporting that may impact offending, an alternative approach to isolating an offending-to-reporting elasticity would be to identify the offending response of a subgroup that is only affected by SC through its effects on victim reporting. In Supplemental Appendix G.7, we conduct exactly this exercise, disaggregating the SC offending impact into effects for Hispanic and non-Hispanic offenders. Specifically, we combine our NCVS victimization effect with SC's impact on the Hispanic arrestee share (Table 4). We estimate that offending perpetrated by *non-Hispanics* against Hispanic civilians increased by 22 percent. This effect translates to a -0.72 offending-to-reporting elasticity, which is remarkably similar to our preferred estimate of -0.79 from the mediation analysis.

Our findings suggest that changes in victim reporting can substantially impact public safety. For comparison, our estimate of the elasticity of offending to victim reporting is quite similar in magnitude to the elasticity of offending to *police force size* (Evans and Owens 2007; Mello 2019; Weisburst 2019), which is consistently cited as a key lever for improving public safety (Chalfin 2025).[37,38]

VIII. Conclusion

Our study provides evidence that reduced crime reporting can negatively impact public safety. To examine the relationship between victim reporting and crime, we study an increase in immigration enforcement via the implementation of the Secure Communities program. We observe a significant reduction in the crime reporting rate of Hispanic victims, consistent with heightened fear of interacting with law enforcement. We also find that Hispanic residents are significantly more likely to become victims of crime. We argue that the decline in reporting is the primary driver of the increased victimization of Hispanic individuals.

Unlike prior studies, we conclude that Secure Communities worsened public safety. To reconcile our findings with previous work, we show that reported crime rates—the standard measure of crime in the literature—remain constant because the decline in victim reporting obscures the true increase in victimization. These

[36] We note an additional factor that may affect the elasticity estimate but is difficult to incorporate into the mediation analysis given available data: potential victims may take protective actions (e.g., staying at home, adding security measures) that could *reduce* victimizations. This would lead us to underestimate the elasticity, yielding a more conservative estimate.

[37] As in the mediation exercise above, we note that elasticities in the economics of crime literature—including for police force size—typically use reported crime as the outcome; thus, they assume that victim reporting behavior does not change as a result of a given policy or intervention.

[38] To facilitate a more direct comparison of effect sizes, in Section G.8 we draw on estimates from Mello (2019) on the fiscal and public safety impacts of police employment. We calculate the per-capita cost at which a policy that increases victim reporting would achieve the same crime-reduction cost-effectiveness as hiring an additional officer. We find that if such a policy could increase victim reporting by 1 percentage point at a cost of \$11.09 per capita, it would produce equivalent crime reduction per dollar spent.

findings overturn the existing empirical work on the SC program and offer an explanation for why previous studies have consistently found null effects.

The divergence between the public safety goals of the SC program and its actual effects has significant policy implications. The public debate surrounding immigration policy often centers on concerns related to immigrant criminality, and views about immigration policy can have wide-ranging political consequences (e.g., Afrouzi, Arteaga, and Weisburst 2024; Ajzenman, Dominguez, and Undurraga 2023; Alesina and Tabellini 2022; Couttenier, Hatte, Thoenig, and Vlachos 2024; Dustmann, Vasiljeva, and Damm 2019). Within this debate, criminal enforcement policies targeting immigrant offenders are frequently promoted as a means to reduce crime. Our findings indicate that these policies may be ineffective, if not counterproductive, due to their potential impacts on community engagement with the police.

Our study offers a number of takeaways for future research. First, our findings demonstrate that the measurement of public safety can be distorted by changes in victim reporting. Given that nearly all studies in the economics of crime literature employ *reported* crime outcomes, researchers should take seriously the possibility that policy interventions may directly affect both reporting behavior and underlying crime. For example, policies that impact racial bias in policing or police use of force could have important ramifications for public trust in law enforcement and, in turn, for victim reporting behavior. An important avenue for future work is to develop a richer model of victim reporting behavior that can accommodate a range of behavioral responses to different criminal justice policy changes. Second, cost-benefit analyses of crime prevention policies should account for the many crimes that are not reported. Researchers may want to scale observed changes in reported offenses by the share of crimes typically reported to law enforcement (e.g., Deshpande and Mueller-Smith 2022; Jácome 2020). If an intervention affects reporting behavior itself, such adjustments must consider these changes as well. Finally, our results underscore the importance of utilizing data sources with granular demographic information to understand the impact of policies targeting certain subgroups. Our work shows that estimating the impact of SC on the full population masks its effects on Hispanic individuals, a group that constitutes 15 percent of the US population.

The effectiveness of government, including law enforcement, can be undermined when policies erode institutional trust. Our work shows that mistrust effects can be large and develop quickly. Confidence in US policing is particularly low in low-income communities (Frydl and Skogan 2004) and has decreased in recent years (Kennedy, Tyson, and Funk 2022). Future research should explore how to design effective public safety policies that do not induce fear among victims and witnesses as well as ways to foster greater community engagement.

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